continuation of their defence ties. A ten-year defence cooperation programme was finalized in 1998 between India and Russia. India and Russia also signed a $2.5 billion deal to set up a nuclear power station in Koodankulam in Tamil Nadu. Further, Indo–Russian ties were strengthened by Putin's visit to India in October 2000. India and Russia also signed the technology transfer deal for production of 150 Sukhoi Su–30 MKI multirole jets in India under Russian licence in December 2000.

China sent a high-powered delegation, led by her Chief of General Staff of the People's Liberation Army (PLA), General Fu Quanyou to India in April 1998 to discuss several bilateral issues. But the Indo–China relations got a jolt due to the Pokhran explosion and also because of identifying China as a potential threat to India's security. This earned the Chinese wrath and the Chinese condemnation of the nuclear tests along with the other major powers. However, gradually, Indo–China relationship began to get normalized following visits by the then External Affairs Minister, Jaswant Singh in 1999 and President K.R. Narayanan in 2000 to China.

India in her bid to normalize relationship sent feelers to Pakistan too. Vajpayee as a part of confidence-building measure with Pakistan inaugurated a bus service from Lahore–Amritsar in February 1999 and he himself took the inaugural bus service to visit the then Prime Minister of Pakistan, Nawaz Sharif in February at Lahore. This was followed by signing of the Memorandum of Understanding (MOU) reaffirming their unilateral moratorium on further nuclear testing and spelling out their confidence-building measures. But the Kargil adventurism of Pakistan during May–June 1999 under General Pervez Musharraf disrupted the peace process. Gradually, relations showed impro-vement and this was followed by General Musharraf's visit to India for talks held in Agra in July 2001. But the talks failed to make any notable breakthrough and even later the strain in Indo–Pak relation continued because of Pakistan's insistence of linking *Kashmir* as the core issue which has always been rejected by India, and India's stand on cross-border terrorism which Pakistan always rejects out of hand. The Kandahar episode revealed the Pakistani connection with the militants, either helped or given shelter by Pakistan. Therefore, like the efforts of the previous governments, the